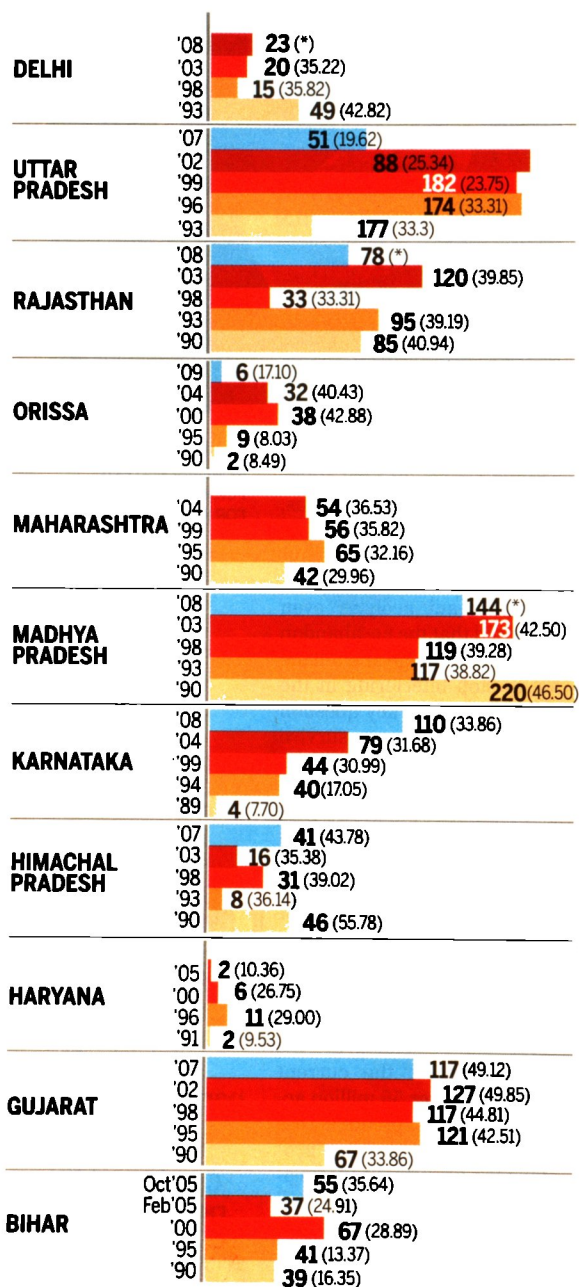


Cover story **BJP**

BUT FOR A FEW GOOD MEN...

Barring a few states like Karnataka and Himachal where the party has gained, it has been losing ground in the assemblies



Figures in bold denote seats; in brackets vote-share of seats contested. All data from Election Commission. * Data not available

The future

CHOUHAN, RAMAN SINGH, MUNDE, YEDDYURAPPA, PARRIKAR, DHUMAL AND MODI



PANKAJ TIWARI



SIPRA DAS

age polling booths. As one senior RSS leader put it: "The BJP without the RSS is like an engine without fuel."

Election 2009 changed it all. The high powered e-campaign launched to propagate the Advani-For-Prime Minister message meant that the old style RSS campaign was conspicuous by its absence. Even the BJP's election manifesto relegated all volatile is-

sues like the Ram Mandir, Article 370 and the Uniform Civil Code to a few paragraphs on the booklet's last page. For the first time since 1952, the top leadership of the RSS was not even consulted on formulating strategy or in the selection of the candidates. A far cry from the '80s and '90s when leaders like Nanaji Deshmukh, Sunder Singh Bhandari, Kushabhau Thakre, J.P. Mathur, all ideologically committed and with a high moral quotient, were deputed to manage the party's political thrust as well as keep a check on the individual aspirations of BJP leaders.

The decline of RSS influence in BJP affairs began with the NDA assuming power which also coincided with changes at the top in the RSS which saw those junior to Advani and Vajpayee at the helm in the parent organisation. Vajpayee's liberal policies infuriated the RSS leadership which, however, could do nothing. When the

For the first time, the BJP dispensed with the old RSS-style campaign. Even key issues like Mandir and Article 370 were relegated to the background.